

place where you can play. I asked the organisers if I could watch it a little bit. Before me, (Ivo) Karlovic and (Andy) Murray were playing. I said, "Please, at least 3-4 games. I would like to watch the atmosphere and everything" because some of the players come in and they cannot even move and breathe because they are so nervous. They let me go. I was watching the spectators almost all the time and did not even pay attention to the game.

At the beginning of the match, my only focus was to not lose 6-0, 6-1, 6-0 because then it's gonna be a disaster, you know? I was focusing on one thing — to hold serve in the first three games and then, it's going to be okay. You're not going to lose badly. I was more relaxed after it. After I lost the first set 6-7, 30-40 percent of the spectators left. I said, "Okay, this is the challenge for me. I like it. I think I would like to call them back, you know?" Then, I won the second and third sets and already, the stadium was full.

Considering Nadal's return from injury in 2024, how tough is it for a professional tennis player to comeback at this stage, late 30s, in his career?

2024 is going to be tough for Rafa. He already said it's going to be his last year. He is playing because of the Olympics, right? And he probably wants to try the French Open. As you get older, it's going to be tough to start again after a break due to injury because you don't know how your body's going to react. It is better if the train is going. If you stop the train, the train is going to start again so slowly. He's practising and already preparing. I saw some videos from Mallorca, his base, and he's hitting the ball really hard. I'm not sure if he can win the Australian Open. I think every round that he's going to win is going to be great for him.

Nick Kyrgios recently said that the current batch of players plays faster and they can beat the older generation. Boris Becker replied to this on X and said Kyrgios does not have any credibility because he



Sunset days: The 38-year-old played for Pune Jaguars in the Tennis Premier League. Ranked 881 in the world, he is close to the end of his career. GETTY IMAGES

hasn't won a major title. What are your thoughts on this argument?

Well, tennis is really fast now. You can see (Carlos) Alcaraz — how is he running, what is he catching and from which angles is he playing? To compare the era when I was playing 10 years ago and now — everybody can now serve at 220kmh. Everybody is hitting the forehands so fast. Before, let's say, my rank was 30 and my opponent was 80. I would think, "This game, I will go only serve-and-volley. This game, I will

play only crosscourt." I wanted to practise and still I won the game. The gap was bigger. Now, in a match between a top-50 player and a top-100, 150 or 200 player, there is a gap of two, three points in every set, which is so small. The Challengers and the ATP250s are pretty even now. Before, the game was so slow. You can see on the videos. Even my coach, he was just playing rallies as they had so much time. Now, there is no chance as the rally will be finished thrice in that time.